

Abstracted Atrocities: How Burgess and Klimov Filtered Violence in Opposite Directions

Come and See (1985), the anti-war film directed by Elem Klimov, depicts the atrocities committed by German occupying forces in the Byelorussian Soviet Socialist Republic. The film follows the journey of Flyora, a young boy who is keen on joining the partisans. The war is shown in its near entirety from his perspective. Anthony Burgess wrote *A Clockwork Orange* after a trip to Leningrad in 1961; the adolescent violence in his novel drew on what he observed in Leningrad. The irony lies in the fact that the Soviet Union gave both works their subjects, but in opposite ways: Burgess observed youths causing minor violence and stylized it into a source of imagined terror while Klimov's *Flyora* is the victim of real terror. Burgess was a visitor; Klimov was a survivor. Both author and filmmaker put distance between their audience and the violence they depicted but used opposite methods: Burgess amplified a minor disorder into a monstrous disease and then shielded the reader from it behind an invented argot, while Klimov took an atrocity too great to be shown in full and reduced it until it could be watched.

In Burgess's 1961 travel essay "The Human Russians," he notes that he arrived in Leningrad expecting to find a "frightening steel-and-stone image of the Orwellian future." What he found instead was "human beings at their most human: or, to put it another way, at their most inefficient."¹ He observed: "That's another thing I liked about Leningrad – the absence of police... perhaps all the police are secret police, and perhaps the only crimes are political crimes," which meant no one was stopping minor misdemeanors such as "drunken disorderliness, rowdyism, soliciting."² Instead, sweating doormen were left to cope with "a loud group of stilyagi or teddy-boys, who were shouting and waving broken bottles and demanding to be let into the restaurant... The painted girls solicited and the teddy-boys raged and romped, but no police came."³ Burgess took this real-world "rowdyism" and amplified it into what the main protagonist, Alex, describes as ultra-violence, demonstrated in this excerpt: "...nor to do the ultra-violent on some shivering starry grey-haired ptitsa in a shop and go smacking off with the till's guts."⁴ This suggests that Burgess's first act of abstraction was not inventing the Nadsat language but rather exaggerating the threat to an unbearable state. It was during this trip that Burgess began formulating "Nadsat," a Russian-inspired language that combines Romany, Russian, and casual rhyming slang; this language served as Burgess's second act of abstraction. Burgess contemplated using contemporary "Teddy Boy" slang but feared that using it would quickly render the book outdated by the time it was published; instead, he invented Nadsat.⁵ By rendering the violence through this foreign, stylized language, Burgess creates a psychological barrier that simultaneously alienates and protects the reader from the raw brutality present in *A Clockwork Orange*.

While Burgess relies on a linguistic "shield" to intellectualize violence, *Come and See* operates on the exact opposite structural philosophy. Klimov removes the stylistic buffer: there is no fabricated language, no narrator. He instead filters at the level of content. Klimov depicts the occupiers' actions not through detached exposition, but through the harrowing, subjective breakdown of Flyora. The viewer is trapped inside the trauma; Klimov holds the camera on Flyora's face, using extreme close-ups to show him visibly aging over the course of the film, and does not give the audience the chance to look away. While Burgess invites the audience to decode violence through text, Klimov uses the visceral immediacy of film; after the bombardment in the forest leaves Flyora deafened, the soundtrack provides the audience with his damaged hearing: a constant ringing, with voices muffled beneath it, so that the viewer hears exactly what he hears. Burgess had amplified a small disorder upwards; Klimov's filtering went

¹ Anthony Burgess, "The Human Russians," *The Listener*, December 28, 1961, 237.

² Burgess, "Human Russians," 241.

³ Burgess, "Human Russians," 242.

⁴ Anthony Burgess, *A Clockwork Orange*, restored ed., ed. Andrew Biswell (London: Penguin, 2013), 8.

⁵ Andrew Biswell, introduction to *A Clockwork Orange*, by Anthony Burgess, restored ed. (London: Penguin, 2013), xxi.

downwards. Klimov had experienced war as a small child: during the Battle of Stalingrad he was evacuated with his mother and brother on a raft across the Volga, later describing his early years simply, "As a young boy, I had been in hell."⁶ The film's co-writer, Ales Adamovich, had fought with the Belarusian partisans as a teenager, and the screenplay drew on his novel *Khatyn* and on *I Am from the Fiery Village*, a collection of survivors' testimony that he co-authored.⁷ Yet Klimov admitted that he had to filter the material downwards: "Had I included everything I knew and shown the whole truth, even I could not have watched it."⁸

Ultimately, both creators recognized that dealing with extreme violence required putting a specific kind of distance between the audience and the atrocity. Burgess achieved this by taking the minor "rowdyism" that he witnessed in Leningrad, magnifying it into ultra-violence, and then filtering it through *Nadsat* so that it could be consumed as stylized fiction. Klimov, however, took an unimaginable hell, his own and that of the villages whose survivors Adamovich recorded, and filtered it downwards so that the truth could be borne at all.

⁶ "Director Not Afraid to Take on the Soviet Authorities," *Irish Times*, November 8, 2003, <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/director-not-afraid-to-take-on-the-soviet-authorities-1.390603>.

⁷ *Come and See*, directed by Elem Klimov, screenplay by Ales Adamovich and Elem Klimov (Moscow: Mosfilm, 1985); Ales Adamovich, *Khatyn* (1971); Ales Adamovich, Yanka Bryl, and Vladimir Kolesnik, *I Am from the Fiery Village* (1977); "Life, Work, and Public Conscience," Ales Adamovich, accessed September 23, 2026, <https://adamovich.eu/en/biography/>.

⁸ "Director Not Afraid," *Irish Times*.